

Country Education Knowledge Base — AI-Servable Facts

Purpose: Grounding knowledge for the Global AI counsellor. Each ## section is a self-contained knowledge chunk designed to be ingested as a separate document (the retrieval pipeline injects ~1,500 chars per article — sections are sized accordingly). **As-of date:** 2026-08-20. Facts marked **[VOLATILE]** change by policy and must be re-verified monthly before serving. Facts marked **[PERIODIC]** should be re-verified quarterly/per intake cycle. Facts marked **[STABLE]** change rarely. **Verification:** ✓ = confirmed against the named primary source during research (Aug 2026). △ = well-established but exact current values must be confirmed at the named source before the AI states them as numbers. **Editorial rule:** entries never generalize institution-level requirements into country-wide rules. Where a fact is institution-specific, the entry says so.

Nepal — School Education System

Nepal's school system runs Grades 1–12. The **Secondary Education Examination (SEE)** is taken at the end of Grade 10, administered by the **National Examinations Board (NEB)**. Grades 11–12 (" +2" / higher secondary) conclude with the **NEB Grade 12 Examination**, Nepal's senior-secondary school-leaving qualification and the standard basis for university entry at home and abroad.

- The NEB was formed in 2016, replacing the former Higher Secondary Education Board (HSEB). Older transcripts say "HSEB" — same qualification lineage. [STABLE]
- School curriculum is set by the **Curriculum Development Centre (CDC)**. [STABLE]
- The Grade 12 qualification is commonly called " +2", "NEB Grade 12", or (older) "Higher Secondary Education Certificate / Intermediate". [STABLE]
- Alongside the NEB stream, Nepal has a vocational stream under **CTEVT** (see the Nepal vocational entry).

Sources: NEB — <https://www.neb.gov.np> ✓ · CDC — <https://moecdc.gov.np> ✓ Note: Nepal's education ministry was restructured in May 2026 (MoEST split); ministry URLs are in flux — verify ministry links before citing. △

Nepal — Grading Systems (two eras — always check which one applies)

Nepal has **two grading eras**, and both appear on real transcripts today:

1. **Letter-grade / GPA era (post-2016 restructuring):** SEE and NEB Grade 12 results are issued as letter grades with a GPA on a **4.0 scale** (A+, A, B+, B, C+, C, D, with non-graded below threshold). The exact current grade boundaries and any post-2021 amendments must be read from NEB's published grading directive. △ Do not state specific percentage-to-letter boundaries without confirming at <https://www.neb.gov.np>. [STABLE once confirmed; boundaries have been amended before]

2. **Percentage era (pre-2016):** older SLC (Grade 10) and HSEB (Grade 12) transcripts use percentages with division bands (Distinction/First/Second/Third Division). Applicants who studied before 2016 hold these. [STABLE — historical]
- University-level grading in Nepal varies by institution: Tribhuvan University traditionally used percentage/division; newer programs and other universities use 4.0-scale GPA or letter grades. Treat university grading as **institution-specific** — read the transcript's own scale. [STABLE]
 - When converting Nepali grades for foreign admission, the conversion is set by the **destination's** recognition authority or university — there is no official Nepali outbound conversion table. [STABLE]

Sources: NEB — <https://www.neb.gov.np> ✓ (grade-boundary tables: confirm current directive before quoting numbers △)

Nepal — Higher Education

- University recognition is governed by the **University Grants Commission (UGC) Nepal** — the authoritative list of recognized Nepali universities and campuses is UGC Nepal's. [STABLE]
- **Tribhuvan University (TU)** is by far the largest university, historically enrolling the large majority of Nepali higher-education students; most Nepali bachelor-degree applicants abroad hold TU or TU-affiliated-college credentials. △ (current enrolment share: confirm at UGC Nepal)
- Bachelor degrees in Nepal are **3 or 4 years depending on program and university** (e.g., many TU humanities programs historically 3 years, later moved to 4; technical programs 4 years). Degree length matters for foreign postgraduate admission — always read the individual transcript. [STABLE]
- Foreign credential evaluators (WES, ECA providers) typically require transcripts **sent directly/sealed by NEB or the university** (e.g., TU), not student copies. ✓ (WES documentation requirements)

Sources: UGC Nepal — <https://www.ugcnepal.edu.np> ✓ · TU — <https://tribhuvan-university.edu.np> △

Nepal — Vocational Education (CTEVT)

The **Council for Technical Education and Vocational Training (CTEVT)** governs Nepal's vocational stream. Its ladder includes short vocational training, **TSLC (Technical School Leaving Certificate)**, **Pre-Diploma**, and **Diploma** programs (e.g., 3-year technical diplomas in engineering, health, agriculture).

- CTEVT diplomas are vocational qualifications, not NEB Grade 12 — destination countries assess them differently from academic +2 credentials, and treatment varies by destination and institution. There is no widely published comparability guidance for CTEVT awards; each case should be checked with the destination's recognition authority. [STABLE structure; recognition treatment △ per destination]

Source: CTEVT — <https://ctevt.org.np> △

Nepal — Studying Abroad: Administrative Requirements

- Nepali students going abroad require a **No Objection Certificate (NOC)** issued by Nepal's education ministry for the specific country and institution. The NOC is also required by banks for foreign-currency exchange for tuition. [PERIODIC — process details change with ministry restructuring; ministry was reorganized May 2026, verify current issuing office △]

Source: Ministry of Education (Nepal) — verify current portal post-restructure [△](#)

Nepal → Australia — Qualification Recognition

- Australian admissions bodies assess the **NEB Grade 12 as an overseas senior secondary qualification** for undergraduate entry. The Universities Admissions Centre (UAC, NSW/ACT) formally lists the Nepalese NEB Grade 12 / Higher Secondary Certificate among assessable overseas qualifications. [✓](#)
- Whether a given NEB GPA meets **direct entry** vs requires a **Foundation program or an AQF Diploma pathway** is an **institution-level decision** — each Australian university publishes its own Nepal entry requirements. Market practice suggests direct-entry thresholds around the high-2s GPA for many universities, but this is third-party corroborated only — **do not state a specific GPA cutoff as a country rule; check the target university's Nepal entry page.** [△](#)
- Australia's authoritative country-comparability reference is the government's **Country Education Profiles (CEP)** (subscription service covering Nepal). [✓](#) (service exists; content licensed)

Sources: UAC overseas qualifications — <https://uac.edu.au/future-applicants/admission-criteria/overseas-qualifications> [✓](#) · CEP — <https://internationaleducation.gov.au> [✓](#) [PERIODIC]

Nepal → UK / Canada / USA — Qualification Recognition

- **UK:** UK universities set their own entry requirements per country (there is no central UK list). Many UK universities ask NEB Grade 12 holders to complete an **International Foundation Year** before a bachelor's degree, while some accept strong NEB results directly — **always check the specific university's Nepal page.** The formal comparability route is a **UK ENIC Statement of Comparability** (see UK recognition entry). Nepal-specific ENIC comparability is not published openly. [△](#) [PERIODIC]
- **Canada:** admission decisions belong to each **DLI** (designated learning institution) — no national equivalency ruling is needed for a study permit. A formal **ECA** (e.g., WES) is required only for skilled-migration purposes such as Express Entry, not for admission. [✓](#) (IRCC)
- **USA:** recognition is decentralized. Universities evaluate Nepali credentials in-house or require a **NACES-member evaluation** (WES, ECE, etc.). Requirements are institution-specific. [✓](#) (NACES)

Sources: <https://www.enic.org.uk> [✓](#) · <https://www.canada.ca> (ECA pages) [✓](#) · <https://naces.org/members> [✓](#)

India — School Education System

India follows a **10+2** structure. Grade 10 concludes with board examinations (Secondary), Grade 12 with the senior-secondary board examination — the standard university-entry qualification.

- **National boards:** CBSE (largest; Class 12 exam = AISCSE) and CISCE (Class 12 = ISC). **NIOS** provides open schooling — some foreign institutions treat NIOS differently from CBSE/CISCE; check the destination institution's policy. [△](#) per institution
- **State boards:** each state runs its own board (~60 boards nationally) with its own syllabus and grading; the board name on the certificate determines which grading scale applies. [STABLE]

- Curriculum reform under **NEP 2020** is progressively reshaping stages and assessment; board structures remain the operative reality for current applicants. [PERIODIC]

Sources: CBSE — <https://www.cbse.gov.in> ✓ · CISCE — <https://www.cisce.org> △ · NIOS — <https://www.nios.ac.in> △

India — Grading Systems

- **Class 12 (boards):** most boards report **percentage marks** per subject; "best of four/five" subject averages are commonly used by universities. CBSE reported CGPA (10-point, with a published ×9.5 conversion) for Class 10 during 2011–2017 before returning to marks — older certificates may show CGPA. △ confirm era on the certificate
- **Universities:** most use a **10-point CGPA**, but the class/division boundaries (First Class, First Class with Distinction, etc.) are **institution-specific** — a 7.5 CGPA maps to different percentage bands at different universities, and many issue their own conversion certificates. Never apply one CGPA→percentage formula nationally. [STABLE as a rule]
- Foreign evaluators either use the issuing university's own conversion or their internal methodology (e.g., WES iGPA) — conversions differ between evaluators. [STABLE]

Sources: CBSE ✓ · UGC — <https://www.ugc.gov.in> ✓

India — Higher Education

- University recognition: **UGC** maintains the authoritative list of recognized universities; **AICTE** approves technical institutions. Degrees from unrecognized institutions are not accepted abroad. [STABLE]
- **Degree length is the critical fact for postgraduate admission abroad:** BA/BSc/BCom are traditionally **3 years**; BE/BTech and most professional degrees are **4 years**; NEP 2020 introduced a 4-year undergraduate option (FYUP). Acceptance of 3-year Indian bachelor's degrees for master's entry **varies by destination and institution** — many UK, Australian and Canadian institutions accept them; US practice historically varied and is institution-specific. Check per institution; do not state a blanket rule. △ per institution [PERIODIC]
- India's **National Credit Framework (NCrF)** (2023) unifies credit accumulation across school, higher and vocational education. ✓ (official framework PDF)
- **AIU (Association of Indian Universities)** issues equivalence for foreign qualifications in the India-bound direction and publishes board-equivalence guidance. ✓

Sources: UGC ✓ · AICTE — <https://www.aicte-india.org> ✓ · AIU — <https://aiu.ac.in/frontpage/equivalence-of-degree/> ✓ · NCrF — <https://dsel.education.gov.in> (framework PDF) ✓

India → UK / Australia — Qualification Recognition

- **UK:** Indian Standard XII from CBSE/CISCE is treated by many UK universities as **comparable to GCE A-level standard for direct undergraduate entry**, with percentage cutoffs set per university (commonly published on each university's India page). ✓ (corroborated on multiple UK university India entry pages; the formal UK ENIC statement is a paid per-credential service)

- **Australia:** CBSE/CISCE Class 12 is standardly accepted for **direct undergraduate entry** with board-percentage cutoffs set per university; state-board treatment varies more. The authoritative comparability reference is Australia's CEP (licensed). ⚠ thresholds per institution [PERIODIC]

Sources: university India entry pages (institution-scoped) ✓ · <https://www.enic.org.uk> ✓ · CEP ✓

Australia — Education System & Qualification Framework (AQF)

Australia's qualifications sit on the **Australian Qualifications Framework (AQF)** — 10 levels spanning schooling, vocational (VET) and higher education:

- Level 1–4: Certificates I–IV (VET) · Level 5: **Diploma** · Level 6: Advanced Diploma / Associate Degree · Level 7: **Bachelor Degree** · Level 8: Bachelor Honours / Graduate Certificate / Graduate Diploma · Level 9: **Masters** · Level 10: **Doctoral**. [STABLE]
- Senior secondary school certificates (Year 12) are recognized within the AQF; each state issues its own (e.g., HSC in NSW, VCE in Victoria). [STABLE]
- Higher-education providers are regulated by **TEQSA** (national register of providers and accredited courses); VET providers by **ASQA** (register on training.gov.au). ✓
- **International students may only enrol in CRICOS-registered courses** — the Commonwealth Register of Institutions and Courses for Overseas Students. If a course is not on CRICOS, it is not open to student-visa holders. ✓ [STABLE rule; register updates monthly]
- Typical durations: Bachelor 3 years (4 with Honours), Masters 1.5–2 years, PhD 3–4 years. Main intakes **February and July**; many providers add a November trimester. [STABLE/PERIODIC]
- University grading is institution-set; the common national vocabulary is HD (High Distinction) / D (Distinction) / C (Credit) / P (Pass). [STABLE]

Sources: AQF — <https://www.aqf.edu.au> ⚠ · TEQSA — <https://www.teqsa.gov.au/national-register> ✓ · CRICOS — <https://cricos.education.gov.au> ✓ (monthly open dataset: <https://data.gov.au/data/dataset/cricos> ✓)

Australia — English Requirements for International Students

Two separate layers — never merge them:

1. **Visa layer (Government, subclass 500)** [VOLATILE — re-verify monthly at homeaffairs.gov.au]: minimum **IELTS 6.0 overall** (or equivalent on an approved test) for a standalone student visa — raised from 5.5 on 23 March 2024; **5.5 accepted when packaged with at least 10 weeks ELICOS**; 5.0 for ELICOS-first pathways. As of **7 August 2025**, 9 tests are approved and **only in-person test formats are accepted — online/at-home versions (e.g., IELTS Online, TOEFL Home Edition) are not valid for visas**. The **Genuine Student** requirement also applies. ✓ (verified Aug 2026)
2. **Admission layer (institution/program)**: universities set their own minimums, typically **at or above** the visa floor (commonly IELTS 6.0–6.5 overall for undergraduate, 6.5+ for postgraduate, higher for nursing/teaching/medicine). These are **institution- and program-specific** — always check the course page. ⚠ per program [PERIODIC]
3. **Duolingo English Test is not accepted for Australian student visas.** ✓

Source: <https://immi.homeaffairs.gov.au> (student visa 500, English requirements) ✓ [VOLATILE]

Australia — Pathways for Students Below Direct Entry

- **Foundation programs** (typically 8–12 months) prepare international students who hold a senior-secondary qualification below direct-entry level for first-year university entry; offered by universities and pathway colleges. [STABLE structure; entry terms per provider △]
- **AQF Diploma → Bachelor articulation**: completing a Diploma (AQF 5) at a university college or TAFE commonly grants entry to **year 2** of a related bachelor's degree ("packaged offers" bundle both with one visa). Credit granted is set by each receiving university. [STABLE structure; credit per institution △]
- **ELICOS packaging**: students below the English requirement can package an English course before the main program at a reduced entry score (see English entry). ✓
- All pathway components must themselves be CRICOS-registered for visa purposes. ✓

Sources: institution/pathway-provider pages (institution-scoped) · CRICOS ✓

Canada — Education System & Recognition

- Canada has **no single national qualifications framework** — education is provincial jurisdiction; each province regulates its institutions and quality assurance. **CICIC** (Canadian Information Centre for International Credentials) is the national information centre for credential questions. ✓ [STABLE]
- **Admission of international students is decided by each institution**. For a study permit, the school must be a **DLI (Designated Learning Institution)** — IRCC publishes the DLI list per province, including which programs/institutions carry **PGWP eligibility**. Always confirm a school's DLI number and PGWP flag before advising. ✓ [PERIODIC — list updates continually]
- **ECA (Educational Credential Assessment)** — a formal equivalency report — is required for **Express Entry (skilled migration)**, and is **NOT required for admission or a study permit**. Designated ECA organizations: **WES, IQAS (Alberta), ICAS, CES (U. of Toronto), ICES (BCIT)**; physicians use MCC, pharmacists PEBC. ECA reports are valid **5 years**. ✓ (IRCC, verified Aug 2026)
- Typical structure: college diplomas (2–3 yrs), bachelor's (3–4 yrs, honours 4), master's (1–2 yrs). College→university transfer pathways are common and province-structured (esp. BC/Ontario). Grading scales vary by institution/province. [STABLE]

Sources: CICIC — <https://www.cicic.ca> ✓ · IRCC ECA — <https://www.canada.ca/en/immigration-refugees-citizenship/services/immigrate-canada/express-entry/documents/education-assessment.html> ✓ · DLI list — [canada.ca DLI page](https://www.canada.ca/en/immigration-refugees-citizenship/services/immigrate-canada/express-entry/documents/education-assessment.html) ✓

Canada — English Requirements

- **Study permit**: there is **no fixed federal English minimum** — the admitting DLI sets the language requirement for admission. ✓ [STABLE rule]
- **Institutional layer**: typical university requirements are around IELTS 6.0–6.5 (undergraduate) and 6.5+ (graduate), **set per institution/program** — check the program page. △ per program [PERIODIC]

- **PGWP (Post-Graduation Work Permit):** applications on/after **1 November 2024** require proof of language ability — **CLB 7** (university graduates) or **CLB 5** (college graduates) **in all four skills**. This is a migration-side rule, separate from admission. ✅ (canada.ca, verified Aug 2026) [VOLATILE]
- Canadian institutions widely accept IELTS, TOEFL iBT, PTE Academic; many accept Duolingo — acceptance is **per institution**. ⚠️

Source: <https://www.canada.ca/en/immigration-refugees-citizenship/services/study-canada/work-after-graduation/eligibility.html> ✅ [VOLATILE]

United Kingdom — Education System & Qualification Frameworks

- England/N. Ireland qualifications sit on the **RQF** (levels Entry–8); higher education uses the **FHEQ** (levels 4–8: 4–5 = certificate/diploma stages, **6 = Bachelor's**, **7 = Master's**, **8 = Doctoral**). Scotland has its own framework (SCQF). Regulated qualifications are listed on the **Ofqual Register**. ✅ [STABLE]
- Bachelor's degrees are typically **3 years in England/Wales/NI** (often 4 in Scotland); master's are commonly **1 year**; PhD 3–4 years. [STABLE]
- **Degree classification** (institution-awarded, national vocabulary): First Class (≈70%+), Upper Second / 2:1 (60–69%), Lower Second / 2:2 (50–59%), Third (40–49%). Postgraduate entry requirements are typically expressed in these classes. [STABLE]
- Undergraduate applications are centralized through **UCAS**. **There is no central UK list of accepted international qualifications — each university decides its own equivalencies** (UCAS confirms this). Institution pages per country are the operative source. ✅ [STABLE rule]
- Main intake September; many taught master's also offer January. [STABLE]

Sources: Ofqual Register — <https://register.ofqual.gov.uk> ✅ · UCAS international — <https://www.ucas.com/international> ✅

United Kingdom — Recognition of Foreign Qualifications (UK ENIC)

- The UK's designated recognition body is **UK ENIC** (operated by Ecctis). It issues a **Statement of Comparability**: an individual document mapping a foreign qualification to UK framework levels. Cost **£49.50** (+ delivery), typical turnaround ~ **15 working days**. ✅ (verified Aug 2026) [PERIODIC — price/turnaround change]
- **Limits of the statement**: it addresses the *level* of the qualification only — it does **not** evaluate grades, subjects, or professional licensure. Universities make their own admission decisions and may not require it. ✅
- For students: an ENIC statement is most useful for employers, professional bodies, and cases where a university asks for it — it is not a routine admission document. [STABLE]

Source: <https://www.enic.org.uk/individuals/statement-of-comparability> ✅

United Kingdom — English Requirements

Two layers [VOLATILE — verify at gov.uk monthly]:

1. **Visa layer (Student visa): degree level and above — CEFR B2** in all four skills; universities licensed as sponsors may **self-assess** how the student meets it (including via their own tests or qualifications).
Below degree level — CEFR B1, proven by a **SELT** (Secure English Language Test) at an approved centre. Approved SELT providers include **IELTS for UKVI, LanguageCert, Trinity College London, PTE Academic UKVI, Skills for English**. ✅ (gov.uk, verified Aug 2026)
2. **Admission layer:** universities set their own requirements (commonly IELTS 6.0–7.0 overall depending on program) — **per institution/program**. ⚠️ [PERIODIC]
3. Standard (non-UKVI) online tests and Duolingo may be accepted by universities for **degree-level admission** under self-assessment, but **not** for below-degree SELT purposes — acceptance is per university. ⚠️

Source: <https://www.gov.uk/guidance/prove-your-english-language-abilities-with-a-secure-english-language-test-selt> ✅ [VOLATILE]

United States — Education System & Recognition

- US higher education is **decentralized**: no national qualifications framework and **no government credential-evaluation body**. Institutional legitimacy rests on **accreditation** (institutional accreditors recognized by CHEA/US Dept of Education). ✅ [STABLE]
- Structure: Associate (2 yrs), **Bachelor's (4 yrs, ~120 semester credits)**, Master's (1–2 yrs), Doctoral. **Credit-hour system** with GPA on a **4.0 scale** (A=4, B=3, C=2, D=1). [STABLE]
- **Foreign credentials:** each university either evaluates in-house or requires a report from a **NACES-member evaluator** (e.g., WES, ECE, IERF, SpanTran). Which evaluator is accepted differs by university — check before paying for a report. ✅ (naces.org)
- **Community college → university transfer** is a standard cost-saving pathway (2 years + 2 years); credit transfer is governed by articulation agreements and receiving-university policy — credit loss without agreements is a documented risk. ✅ (GAO research)
- International enrolment requires admission to an **SEVP-certified school** (issues the I-20 for the F-1 visa). ✅ [STABLE rule]
- Intakes: Fall (Aug/Sep, main), Spring (Jan), sometimes Summer. Undergraduate testing (SAT/ACT) is now **optional at many institutions** — policy is per university. ⚠️ per institution [PERIODIC]

Sources: NACES — <https://naces.org/members> ✅ · SEVP — <https://www.ice.gov/sevis> ⚠️ · travel.state.gov (student visas) ✅

United States — English Requirements

- **There is no US government English minimum for the F-1 visa** — the SEVP-certified school determines English proficiency before issuing the I-20; the consular interview assesses the applicant overall. ✅ (verified Aug 2026) [STABLE rule]
- **All English requirements are institutional:** typical ranges are TOEFL iBT ~61–100 / IELTS ~6.0–7.0 depending on institution and level; **Duolingo English Test is widely accepted by US institutions**. Always check the specific university's published minimums. ⚠️ per institution [PERIODIC]

- Note: ETS introduced a **new 1–6 band scale for TOEFL** reported alongside the traditional 0–120 score — expect both on recent score reports. ✓ (ets.org)

Sources: <https://travel.state.gov/content/travel/en/us-visas/study/student-visa.html> ✓ · <https://www.ets.org/toefl> ✓

Bangladesh — Education System (Origin Summary)

- Structure: **SSC** (Secondary School Certificate, Grade 10) and **HSC** (Higher Secondary Certificate, Grade 12) — HSC is the university-entry qualification. Administered by **11 regional BISE education boards** plus Madrasah and Technical boards; the board name determines the certificate stream. [STABLE]
- Grading: SSC/HSC use a **GPA on a 5.0 scale** (A+ = 5.0). Foreign institutions set their own HSC GPA cutoffs — treatment is per destination institution. ⚠ per institution
- University recognition: **UGC Bangladesh** maintains the list of recognized public and private universities. ✓
- Bachelor's degrees: 4-year honours degrees are standard at universities; 3-year pass degrees exist — degree type matters for postgraduate admission abroad. [STABLE]

Sources: UGC Bangladesh — <http://www.ugc.gov.bd> ✓ · education boards — <https://dhakaeducationboard.gov.bd> ⚠

Pakistan — Education System (Origin Summary)

- Structure: **SSC/Matric** (Grade 10) and **HSSC/Intermediate** (Grade 12, e.g., FSc/FA), administered by provincial boards. **IBCC** (Inter Boards Coordination Commission) issues **equivalence certificates for school-level qualifications** — including assessing foreign school credentials against SSC/HSSC. ✓
- Higher education: regulated by **HEC (Higher Education Commission)**, which maintains the recognized-university list and runs **degree attestation** — foreign evaluators and employers commonly require HEC-attested degrees. ⚠ (process details at hec.gov.pk)
- **Degree length is critical:** older 2-year BA/BSc "pass" degrees are generally **not** accepted as bachelor-equivalent by most foreign graduate schools, while the 4-year BS is. The 2-year associate degree has been replacing the 2-year BA/BSc. Check the credential's duration, always. [STABLE as a caution; per-institution treatment ⚠]
- Grading: division system (First/Second/Third) and percentage historically; newer programs use 4.0-scale CGPA. [STABLE]

Sources: IBCC — <https://ibcc.edu.pk/equivalence-intro/> ✓ · HEC — <https://www.hec.gov.pk> ⚠

Sri Lanka — Education System (Origin Summary)

- Structure follows the UK pattern: **GCE O-Level** (Grade 11) and **GCE A-Level** (Grade 13) administered by the **Department of Examinations**. The A-Level is the university-entry qualification (3 subjects in streams). ✓
- Because Sri Lanka uses UK-style GCE qualifications, destination mapping is comparatively straightforward — many foreign universities publish Sri Lankan A-Level grade requirements directly

alongside UK A-Level requirements. ⚠ per institution

- Grading: A-Level grades A/B/C/S/F; a Z-score system governs domestic university admission (domestic-only mechanism — not used abroad). [STABLE]
- University recognition: **UGC Sri Lanka**. Bachelor's degrees are 3 years (general) or 4 years (special/honours) — the distinction matters for postgraduate admission abroad. [STABLE]

Sources: Dept of Examinations — <https://www.doenets.lk> ✓ · UGC Sri Lanka — <https://www.ugc.ac.lk> ⚠

New Zealand — Education System & Recognition (Destination Summary)

- Qualifications sit on the **NZQCF** (New Zealand Qualifications and Credentials Framework), 10 levels: 1–4 certificates, 5–6 diplomas, **7 = Bachelor's**, 8 = Honours/PGCert/PGDip, **9 = Master's**, **10 = Doctoral**. Administered by **NZQA**. ✓ [STABLE]
- **International Qualification Assessment (IQA)**: NZQA's formal evaluation of overseas qualifications against the NZQCF — required for some purposes unless the qualification is on NZQA's **exemption list**; Immigration New Zealand relies on IQA outcomes. Admission itself is set by each institution. ✓
- Bachelor's 3 years (honours +1), master's 1–2 years. Intakes February and July. English requirements are set per institution (typically IELTS 6.0 UG / 6.5 PG); visa-side English rules per Immigration NZ. ⚠ [PERIODIC/VOLATILE]

Source: NZQA IQA — <https://www2.nzqa.govt.nz/international/recognise-overseas-qual/> ✓

Ireland — Education System & Recognition (Destination Summary)

- Qualifications sit on the Irish **NFQ** (National Framework of Qualifications), 10 levels: **6 = Advanced/Higher Certificate**, 7 = Ordinary Bachelor, **8 = Honours Bachelor**, **9 = Master's**, **10 = Doctoral**. Managed by **QQI**. ✓ [STABLE]
- **QQI provides FREE downloadable comparability statements for 2,000+ foreign qualifications from 170+ countries** via its qualification-recognition search — the most accessible official equivalency source of any major destination. Use it to state how a specific foreign qualification maps to NFQ levels. ✓
- Honours bachelor's 3–4 years; taught master's 1 year. Institution-set English requirements (typically IELTS 6.0–6.5). ⚠ per institution [PERIODIC]
- The NFQ is referenced to the **EQF**, enabling crosswalks to other European frameworks. ✓

Sources: QQI — <https://www.qqi.ie/recognition-of-foreign-qualifications> ✓ · search — <https://qsearch.qqi.ie/webpart/search?searchtype=recognitions> ✓

Germany — Education System & Recognition (Destination Summary)

- University admission for foreign students turns on whether the school-leaving certificate confers **HZB (university entrance qualification)**. The official database is **anabin** (run by ZAB/KMK): it rates foreign **institutions** (H+ recognized / H– not / H+/- conditional) and **school certificates/degrees** for German equivalence. ⚠ (German-language database — verify entries directly)

- **Students with 12-year school systems (including Nepal and India Class 12) generally do not qualify for direct university entry** and typically complete a **Studienkolleg** (one-year foundation) ending in the **Feststellungsprüfung**, or one year of recognized university study at home first — subject-stream (T/W/G/S courses) matters. ✓ (uni-assist guidance; per-case confirmation via anabin/uni-assist △)
- If anabin has no entry, the **ZAB Statement of Comparability** is the individual assessment route. ✓
- Most universities process international applications via **uni-assist**, which pre-checks documents (VPD). ✓
- Public universities charge little/no tuition (semester fees apply; Baden-Württemberg charges non-EU fees). Language of instruction matters: German-taught programs require German proficiency (TestDaF/DSH); English-taught programs require IELTS/TOEFL per institution. △ [PERIODIC]

Sources: anabin — <https://anabin.kmk.org> △ · ZAB — <https://www.anerkennung-in-deutschland.de> ✓ · uni-assist — <https://www.uni-assist.de/en/> ✓

English Tests — Scales and Cross-Country Acceptance

Test scales [STABLE, except noted]:

- **IELTS (Academic)**: bands 0–9 in 0.5 steps; four skills each banded; overall = average. IELTS for UKVI is the same test at approved centres for UK visa purposes.
- **TOEFL iBT**: 0–120 (four sections 0–30). ETS now also reports a **new 1–6 band scale alongside 0–120** — recent score reports show both. ✓
- **PTE Academic**: 10–90. A separate **PTE Academic UKVI** version exists for UK visa routes.
- **Duolingo English Test**: 10–160, online-only.
- **Cambridge C1 Advanced**: 160–210 (Cambridge scale).

Acceptance matrix — admission vs visa are different questions [VOLATILE — verify monthly]:

- **Australia (visa)**: approved-test list (9 tests as of Aug 2025), **in-person formats only; Duolingo NOT accepted for visas**. Institutions may accept more tests for admission than the visa allows — the visa list wins for enrolment. ✓
- **UK (visa)**: degree level = B2 with university self-assessment (universities may accept regular IELTS/TOEFL/PTE/Duolingo); below degree = SELT only (IELTS for UKVI, LanguageCert, Trinity, PTE UKVI, Skills for English). **Duolingo is not a SELT**. ✓
- **Canada**: admission tests per DLI (IELTS/TOEFL/PTE/Duolingo widely accepted); PGWP requires CLB-mapped proof (IELTS/CELP/IPTE Core) — a separate, migration-side requirement. ✓
- **USA**: entirely institutional; Duolingo widely accepted. ✓
- **Score conversions between tests**: only test-owner published concordances are valid; do not convert scores ad hoc. [STABLE rule]

Sources: ielts.org △ · ets.org/toefl ✓ · pearsonpte.com ✓ · englishtest.duolingo.com △ · gov.uk SELT list ✓ · homeaffairs.gov.au ✓

Recognition Principles — How Qualification Comparability Works Globally

- The **Lisbon Recognition Convention** (1997, Europe/North America and others) sets the governing principle: a foreign qualification **must be recognized unless the assessing body demonstrates a substantial difference** from the comparable local qualification. The **UNESCO Global Convention** (2019, in force 2023) extends fair-recognition principles globally. ✓ [STABLE]
- **Framework level ≠ admission.** A comparability statement (e.g., "comparable to RQF Level 3") establishes level, not entry: universities still apply their own grade, subject, and English requirements. Never present an equivalency statement as an admission guarantee. [STABLE]
- **Who decides, by destination:** Australia — universities decide, informed by the government's Country Education Profiles; UK — each university decides (UK ENIC statements are advisory); Canada — each DLI decides admission (ECA is for migration); USA — each university decides (NACES evaluations advisory); NZ — NZQA IQA formalizes level; Ireland — QQI publishes free comparability guidance; Germany — anabin/ZAB determine HZB. ✓
- **UNESCO ISCED 2011** is the neutral international classification (levels 0–8) used to compare systems: senior secondary ≈ ISCED 3, bachelor ≈ ISCED 6, master ≈ ISCED 7, doctorate ≈ ISCED 8. Useful for explaining level relationships between any two countries. ✓ [STABLE]

Sources: coe.int (Lisbon Convention) ✓ · unesco.org (Global Convention) ✓ · uis.unesco.org (ISCED) ⚠

Maintenance: sections marked [VOLATILE] expire 30 days after the as-of date and must be re-verified before serving; [PERIODIC] sections expire after one intake cycle (~4 months); [STABLE] sections require an annual sweep. Items marked ⚠ must not be quoted as specific numbers until confirmed at the named source.